could not evolve beyond their Great Game thinking, or the optimism of 1918, to accept the realities of 1920. By their stubbornness, the likes of Curzon and Lloyd George arguably made what was a bad year for the British Empire even worse.

Mutiny and Revolution

Compounding the difficult international scene, Britain was facing its own domestic problems in 1920. Although the country had experienced an economic boom in the months immediately after the armistice, this was short-lived. By 1920, rising inflation and unemployment were causing widespread public discontent within Britain, and the year would experience a surge in labour unrest and industrial action.[3] Particularly worrying, however, was the apparent influence of Bolshevism on Britain's domestic strife at this time. The 'Hands off Russia' movement, for example, organised protests against the government's involvement in the Soviet–Polish conflict of 1920.[4] In January 1919, during violent clashes between police and workers in Glasgow, a red flag was raised on the flag pole of the city chambers. That troops, tanks and machine guns were called in to occupy the city and end 'The Battle of George Square' is indicative of just how much the British government feared a Bolshevik-style uprising in the country.[5]

To make matters worse, in 1918 and 1919 the police force themselves had gone on strike, and could no longer be entirely relied on to keep the peace in the face of other workers' protests.[6] As for the army, in January 1919 troops stationed in Dover and Folkestone had rebelled at the slow demobilisation process.[7] By 1920 there was a likelihood that should a general strike occur – as the Triple Alliance was threatening in the autumn – the authorities might find the police and a large group of ex-soldiers joining the workers.[8] As a report of the Home Office put it, 'in the event of rioting, for the first time in history the rioters will be better trained than the troops'.[9] So seriously did the Chief of the Imperial General Staff (CIGS), Sir Henry Wilson, view the situation that, in January 1920, he set his men to prepare plans for 'mutiny and revolution' in Britain.[10] Such fear regarding